would it have been like if I hadn't turned up at all?'

What the manager said next, I'll never forget:

'When I saw you turn up there, I questioned your loyalty to Manchester United.'

That stung. I couldn't believe I was hearing it, to be honest. I'd been at the club for thirteen years.

'I love United. I want to be here. But if you don't want me to be, you should tell me.'

The boss didn't answer. I walked out. And, in the days afterwards, it was like the conversation hadn't happened at all. In training, it felt like I was on the end of the worst criticism, whatever I did, for no real reason at all. The manager's never been afraid to change things at United. I got my chance in the first team, after all, because he sold Andrei Kanchelskis. Now it was beginning to feel like I was the one being set up for the chop. We were all used to getting grief from the boss: for years it had been one way of him getting the best out of his players. This wasn't like that, though. It was personal and it was humiliating. Try as I might to carry on as normal, the situation got to me. Ask Victoria: she had her own worries with Romeo being so young. And she hated the fact that I was so down and depressed the whole time. It wasn't her fault was it? But she was the one who got it in the ear day after day from an unhappy husband.

That meeting with the manager hadn't resolved anything. Even after I'd got back to full fitness and was playing again in the team, it seemed I couldn't do anything right in his eyes. Before Christmas, the players would go to local hospitals, bringing presents for the kids. The previous couple of years, we'd spread things around a bit by me and Victoria going to a different hospital, the Christie Cancer Hospital in Manchester, and I made the mistake of asking whether we should do the same thing again. The boss saw that as me snubbing the rest of the team, wanting to be different and wanting to be treated differently—none of which was anything like the truth—and pulled me to one side to give me a piece of his mind about it.

The day of our game against Chelsea at Old Trafford in the Worthington Cup, Brooklyn had his first nativity play at nursery school. We trained in the morning and were due to meet up at one o'clock to prepare for the game. I asked the manager if I could report a few minutes late: the play started at midday and lasted about an hour. Maybe I should have known not to even